The school was inside what used to be a municipal building. Concrete, squat, ugly, and reinforced like someone expected it to take heavy fire. The windows were narrow, the walls were thick, and everything smelled faintly of dust, old paper, and oddly enough fresh cedar from the newly built desks.

Robby stood just inside the doorway, backpack slung over one shoulder, trying not to look like he wanted to bolt. It had been some years since he had to do this whole “formal education” thing, so he was a bit confused at how this operated.

Kids filled the room. Too many. Voices layered over each other in a way that made his shoulders tense. He cataloged exits automatically before he realized he was doing it. Finally he found his way to an empty table, each of the fresh cedar tables fit two students so he found an empty spot near the back corner so he didn’t have his back to the door or the room.

A woman with graying hair and tired eyes, Ms. Calder, according to the board, called names. Ages ranged all over the place. Some kids looked barely able to read. Others already carried themselves like adults who’d just been shrunk.

The first lesson was basic math. Robby finished it in minutes. Then rechecked it. Then checked it again. He raised his hand once to ask if he’d misunderstood the instructions.

Ms. Calder frowned, looked over his work, then stared at him for a long second.

“…You can work ahead,” she said carefully.

The next subject was history. He was lost within ten minutes. He really failed to see the point of studying a government that everyone now said was collapsed. Robby felt like it was like memorizing a math equation that had been proven wrong, entirely pointless.

Dates. Political structures. Names of places that no longer existed. When they talked about city-states, he knew what *that* meant at least, from his personal reading of ancient Greek and Romans. When they talked about treaties and governments of the last two hundred years, it might as well have been fiction.

Science was worse and better at the same time.

He knew how batteries worked because he’d needed them to live. He knew structural engineering because roofs collapsed if you didn’t. But when they started talking about formal terminology; units, theories, and standardized methods, he felt stupid for the first time in a long while.

He didn’t raise his hand, the teacher didn’t look very willing to answer questions. He would just ask Sarah late.

Lunch was chaos.

He sat at the edge of a table, back to a wall, eating slowly while listening more than he talked. A couple kids stared at the scar on his leg when it showed. One asked if it was from a knife.

“No,” Robby said. “A boar.”

They didn’t ask follow-ups.

Then he saw her.

She was standing near the windows, light catching in her hair like it had decided to highlight her specifically. She was laughing, actually laughing, not the sharp defensive kind. Something about it hit him hard, right in the chest, like he’d been punched gently but precisely.

Laura.

He didn’t know her name yet. He just knew that everything else in the room dimmed when she moved. That she looked… unreal. Like someone from a better story had wandered into his by accident.

She noticed him looking.

Robby froze.

She smiled.

That was it. No lightning. No music. Just a small, genuine honest smile.

Robby blushed and looked down at his food like it had personally betrayed him.

The rest of the day passed in fragments. Writing exercises he struggled with because his handwriting was utilitarian and ugly. Practical problem-solving he crushed without trying. Social rules he didn’t understand at all.

At the end of the day, Ms. Calder stopped him.

“Don’t worry, Steve already told me about your… well… recent living situation,” she said, choosing her words carefully. “We will get you caught up, don’t you worry about it too much.”

Robby nodded, not sure what that meant but deciding to trust her anyway. When he stepped outside, the air was cold and clean. He spotted Steve near the gate, talking with someone from the fort. Robby’s eyes drifted back to the building.

Laura stood near the door, talking to her friends. She laughed again.

Robby felt something unfamiliar settle in his chest.

Not fear.
Not hunger.

Something worse.
Hope.

It was early afternoon, unusually warm for late spring, and the school had organized swimming lessons at the reservoir. Robby hadn't wanted to go at first, but Ms. Calder insisted. "Everyone participates. No exceptions."

The other kids changed quickly, chattering and splashing. Robby peeled off his shirt and tossed it onto the bench. That's when a few of the students noticed something new.

On his chest was the halo and wings, the dark black ink with faint silver highlights glinting in the sun. A tattoo.

Tony, one of the older boys, nudged his friends. "What the… did you… get that done?"

Robby tensed slightly. "Yeah," he said, casually, though there was pride behind it. "Trixie from Ravenholt did it. I helped her clean her basement, run a few errands, and bring her some fresh boar meat. She said I earned it."

A murmur ran through the group. Kids stared, some impressed, some uneasy.

Then came the scars, on his chest, zigzagging lines from fights and accidents he didn't explain, and along his leg, the long pale mark left by the boar tusk. Tony's face twisted between awe and fear.

"You… really did fight a boar?" he whispered.

"Yeah," Robby said flatly. "Got my licks in, too." He eased into the water, leaving a few stunned whispers behind him. A couple of kids followed, splashing awkwardly. Most seemed to keep a wary distance.

Laura watched him from the dock, towel in hand, eyes bright with curiosity. She didn't speak at first. Then quietly, leaning toward a friend, she said, "He's… different."

And Robby, sensing her tone, not judgmental, not fearful, just *interested*… felt the smallest flicker of connection.

By the end of the lesson, a few kids had stopped whispering outright, giving him space. Others kept their distance, unsure how to approach him. Robby didn't mind. He had swum, endured the stares, and left the water the same way he had come: strong, quiet, and untouched by their curiosity in ways they couldn't understand.

Laura came down to the edge as he climbed out, brushing water from her hair. "You're… good," she said softly.

Robby glanced at her, a faint smile tugging at his lips. "I've had practice. The best way to stay cool in the middle of summer was just to jump into the lake."

She laughed lightly, and for a moment, all the scars, the tattoo, the whispers… they didn't matter. He had her attention, and that made him feel almost normal.

The first school year stretched before Robby like a new kind of map. Unknown streets, strange rules, and the constant hum of voices that didn't pause for him. He adapted quickly in some areas and stumbled in others. Sarah for filling in gaps in his knowledge, and Steve to help him learn to fight and hunt even better.

Math and practical science were effortless. He could measure the angles of a desk leg and tell you how much load it could carry before snapping. He could repair a broken water pump with half the parts missing. History and grammar, though? Nearly alien. He struggled with dates, names, and rules that felt arbitrary. Sometimes he read the lessons twice, sometimes three times, and still left the room unsure he'd gotten them "right."

Lunches became small lessons in social maneuvering. He sat with Laura whenever he could. She asked questions that made him feel slightly ridiculous but also *seen*, and he started to learn how to answer without spilling all the knowledge in his head. Other kids came and went, some curious, some wary. A few tried to challenge him, at first.

Evenings were mostly his own. He labored on the house, measuring, cutting, and fitting beams together. Steve would drop by occasionally, offering advice on reinforcement or solar wiring. Sarah sometimes checked the panels, asking questions about the angle and efficiency. Robby liked these quiet hours best; the smell of timber, the scrape of metal, and the satisfaction of seeing walls rise from nothing.

Weekends became explorations of Silvercreek and its surroundings. He and Laura would walk the dam walls, joke about small things, or silently watch the water flow beneath. A few other classmates tagged along occasionally, learning to respect the balance between his strange skills and his outsider demeanor.

When school finally let out for summer, Robby expanded his reach. He met a farmer living a few miles north of Silvercreek, a man named Tom who welcomed help in exchange for work. Robby learned to drive the tractor properly, baling hay and repairing fences. In return, he earned two acres to plant crops, a coop for his chickens, and a safe place for Nina. The cat, predictably, thrived. She hated the city, loved open fields, and devoted herself to chasing mice and guarding the grain like it was her sworn duty.

The rhythm of summer was simple but fulfilling. Days were spent in the fields, evenings building the house, and late afternoons wandering the edges of the Silvercreek with Laura or a small group of friends. Small mistakes happened. An overwatered plot, a spilled grain barrel, a broken fence post, but they were contained, lessons learned, never devastating.

By the end of the summer, Robby had grown in subtle ways. He could fit into school routines, navigate social interactions a bit better, and maintain his work ethic without isolation. He still remained, in minor ways, apart: careful, methodical, tuned to survival instincts that others no longer needed. Yet the new friendships he had made, and the small corner of the world he had claimed at the farm, made the outsider role feel less like loneliness and more like choice.

And through it all, there was Laura. Always a fixed point in a confusing, crowded world. Her laughter, her curiosity, the way she watched him without judgment. She was constant, and quietly, Robby realized that for the first time, he could imagine himself not just surviving, but living.

The evening sun slanted low, golden across the half-finished walls of Robby's house. Dust swirled in the air as he hammered a beam into place, his gloves rough against the wood.

"Hold it steady!" he called, jarring slightly as the beam shifted under the weight.

Steve stepped up beside him, bracing the other end. "Got it. You think these boards are heavy? Wait till you start lifting the shingles."

"Shingles? I'm going with a metal roof," he huffed, squinting against the sun, then glanced down the path. Laura was standing near the pile of boards, her hands on her hips, watching him like she'd been doing for the last ten minutes. Next to her, her father carried a bucket of nails, shifting awkwardly as though the weight of it offended him.

"Not too heavy?" Robby asked.

Laura's dad shook his head. "Na, just been a long day and too many years sitting at a desk." as he sat the bucket down.

Laura smiled, stepping forward to hand him a smaller beam. "Here. You'll want this one for the corner."

Robby accepted it carefully. "Thanks," he said, trying not to sound too grateful. Gratitude wasn't something he was practiced at expressing.

Steve clapped him on the shoulder. "Looks good, kid. At this rate we may actually be finished by winter. Which winter is up for debate but definitely by winter."

Robby grinned. "I wonder how Sarah stays with you with that lack of humor you have."

"He has good attributes," Sarah teased. "Just, humor isn't one of them."

Laura and Robby laughed as Steve feigned mock indignation

Her dad crouched to pick up a dropped nail. "You sure you're doing all this yourself most nights?" he asked, glancing around at the partially finished walls. "This isn't exactly a small project."

"I like doing it myself," Robby said simply, gripping the beam tighter. "But it's nice having help."

Steve nudged him with his elbow. "See? You can accept help without it meaning you're weak."

Robby frowned, thinking about that. Accepting help didn't come naturally, but standing here, with hands on beams, sweat on his brow, and people he trusted around him… maybe it wasn't so bad.

Sarah straightened, brushing sawdust from her hands. "That corner's aligned. Let's nail it in before the sun goes completely."

Laura handed Robby a hammer. He worked alongside her, feeling the rhythm of the nails, and the beat of wood striking metal. Steve took one side, her father the other, Sarah finishing the solar panel alignment.

For the first time in a long while, Robby felt the walls growing around him not just as a structure, but as a little world he belonged to.

When the last nail went home and the beam was solid, they all stepped back. The sunlight caught on the new corner, turning it a warm, forgiving gold.

Laura smiled. "Looks perfect."

Robby nodded, letting himself smile back. Not at the house, not at the beams, not at the work, but at the people standing there beside him.

The sun had slipped low behind the trees, soft light washing over the half-finished house. Robby wiped his hands on his pants, leaving streaks of sawdust along the knees. The air smelled of pine, earth, and metal, the scent of work done, of progress.

"Not bad for a day's work," Laura said from the edge of the yard, brushing a strand of hair behind her ear. She'd watched him hammer, measure, and adjust beams for what felt like hours. "I didn't think we'd get this far before sunset."

Robby shrugged, a little uncomfortable with the praise. "I had good help today," he muttered. But this time, he meant the practice of doing things alone, the long hours of planning and building, the muscle memory and stubbornness it took to turn raw cut boards into walls.

Laura stepped closer, watching the structure. "It's… kind of amazing. You made this."

He felt a little heat in his chest, but it wasn't embarrassment. It was pride, faint and steady, the kind that came from doing something with his own hands. He kicked at a small rock near the porch and gestured toward the farm a few miles north. "You want to go do something?"

Her eyes lit up. "You mean… the tractor?"

Robby nodded vigorously. He led her down the dirt path to Old Man Tom's farm, where the tractor waited beside neatly stacked hay bales. The engine was quiet now, but he knew its hum intimately, having driven it hundreds of times over the summer.

He lifted the seat for her to climb in, hands steady on the controls. "It's easy. Just watch the pedals and the levers. Don't worry, it won't go anywhere fast."

Laura’s fingers lingered on the gear shift, then she looked at him, eyes wide. “You trust me?”

“I do,” he said simply. “Just don’t hit the fence.”

She laughed softly, and he smiled, a little too self-conscious to admit how much that laugh grounded him. “Okay,” she said, and nudged the pedal. The tractor rumbled to life under her hands, hesitant at first, then steady.

Nina appeared at that moment, padding up the path with her tail high, ears flicking back and forth. She meandered around Laura’s legs before brushing against Robby’s boots, rubbing her head insistently.

“She likes you,” Robby said. “Or maybe she just tolerates you.”

Laura bent down to scratch behind Nina’s ears. “I think she likes me. Or she’s judging me. Never can tell with cats.”

“Either way,” Robby said, “you passed the first test.”

The tractor moved slowly across the small field, grass swaying in the light breeze, and Robby guided her gently, keeping a hand near the wheel but letting her steer. He pointed out the rows, the small markers Old Man Tom had left, and watched her grin as she maneuvered the machine like she’d been born to it.

Evening stretched around them as they rode the tractor, long shadows falling across the fields. For the first time since leaving Ravenholt, he didn’t feel like an outsider. He felt… exactly where he was supposed to be. And somewhere deep inside, he hoped that this; the building, the working, learning, laughing, surviving. This was only the beginning.